Institution: Museum of Fine Arts, Boston
Registration Number: 90.155a
Beazley Archive Number: 207187
Fabric: Athenian, red-figure
Shape: Stamnos
Attribution: Villa Giulia Painter, Beazley
Date: Early Classical, c. ~450 BCE
Dimensions: H. 47.4 cm; D. 33.4 cm
Place of Manufacture: Greece, Attica, Athens
Provenance: Gift of Edward Perry Warren, purchased in Rome

Fabric, Technique, Shape & Condition
Attic red-figure stamnos with lid. The lid is decorated with rays and concentric circles. The vessel has been repaired from a break, with visible seams; the black glaze is well-reserved. A continuous figural frieze encircles the body as the principal decorative scheme (fig. 1.)

Fig. 1. *Stamnos depicting women congregated about an idol of Dionysos (panoramic view, encircling frieze)*, c. 450 BCE. Attic red-figure. Museum of Fine Arts, Boston, 90.155a. Image © Museum of Fine Arts, Boston.

Iconography The frieze depicts a Dionysian ceremony organised around a mask-idol of Dionysos: a bearded mask attached to a column, from which a chiton and himation hang, with ivy sprigs projecting above.[1] Before the idol stands a three-legged table bearing a sacrificial cake, flanked by two amphorae. On side A, two women stand on either side of the table, each holding a skyphos. The woman to the right dips a ladle into a stamnos positioned before her. The depicted stamnos mirrors the vessel itself, creating a self-referential visual echo well attested in the mask-idol series, of which this vessel is a part of.[2] On side B, three women move in procession. The leftmost holds a skyphos in her right hand, her left resting on the back of a chair. The central figure carries a parasol, marking the outdoor and extramural nature of the gathering. The rightmost figure also holds a skyphos. The women throughout are depicted as dignified, unhurried figures, distinguished by the lack of ecstatic poses nor maenadic attributes.[3]

The scene belongs to a group conventionally termed the "Lenaia vases", a series of red-figure stamnoi attributed primarily to the Villa Giulia painter and his followers, the Chicago Painter. The vessels in this series depict women gathered before a mask-idol of Dionysus.[4] The precise identification of the festival depicted remains debated. Boardman notes that similar scenes are often associated with the Lenaia festival or an episode in the spring Anthesteria by scholars.[5] Carpenter notes that the women on this vessel are visually "no different" from nymphs in the painter's Dionysiac works,

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[1] Carpenter, Thomas H. *Dionysian Imagery in Fifth-Century Athens*. Clarendon, 2024. https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780198150381.001.0001.
[2] Classical Art Research Centre, University of Oxford. "Villa Giulia Painter Stamnos with Stamnoi." Introduction to Greek Pottery: Key Pieces — Attic Red-Figure. Accessed April 6, 2026. https://www.carc.ox.ac.uk/carc/resources/Introduction-to-Greek-Pottery/Keypieces/redfigure/villa.
[3] Carpenter, *Dionysian Imagery*, 2024.
[4] Ibid.
[5] Boardman, John. *Athenian Red Figure Vases: The Classical Period*. London: Thames and Hudson, 1989.

complicating their interpretation as representations of civic participants.[6] The host institution, however, identifies the participants as moral women at a state-sponsored Dionysiac festival, following the general interpretive consensus. The scene is therefore best understood more broadly within the context of Dionysiac cult practice, particularly in relation to mask-idol worship and extramural ritual activity.

Attribution & Dating Attributed to the Villa Giulia Painter by Beazley.[7] The Villa Giulia Painter is the leading figure of a closely related group of Early Classical painters whose compositions are characterised as quiet and harmonious. The painter is particularly associated with larger vessels, including stamnoi, hydriai, and pelikai, and is regarded as a principal contributor to the mask-idol series, which depicts women before the Dionysiac idol on at least ten stamnoi.[8]A closely comparable stamnos in the Ashmolean Museum exhibits the same stamnos-within-stamnos motif and a similar compositional structure (Fig. 2).

Fig. 2. *Stamnos with stamnoi, Side A (left) and Side B (right),* c. 450 BCE. Attic red-figure. Ashmolean Museum, University of Oxford, AN1896-1908.G.279. Image © Classical Art Research Centre, University of Oxford

The series is dated mostly to around the middle of the 5th century.[9] A date of c. 450 BCE is consistent with the painter's known activity and with the stylistic character of the figural work, which is further confirmed by the dates attributed on the Beazley archive entry.[10]

[6] Carpenter, *Dionysian Imagery*, 2024.
[7] Classical Art Research Centre, University of Oxford. "Beazley Archive Pottery Database." Record C151551A-12B4-44FE-B447-C719702B96F5 (Vase no. 207187). Accessed April 6, 2026. https://www.beazley.ox.ac.uk/record/C151551A-12B4-44FE-B447-C719702B96F5.

[8] Boardman, *Attic Red- Figure,*1989; Carpenter, *Dionysian Imagery*, 2024.
[9] Carpenter, *Dionysian Imagery*, 2024.
[10] Classical Art Research Centre, *Beazley Archive Database.*

Works Cited

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